

Five Steps to Financial Wellbeing

they worried about money also said that they had never sought advice or guidance.² I see this anecdotally in my work too – people often speak about being too terrified to engage with their finances, especially when they fear that things aren't going well or according to plan. It's probably one of the major stumbling blocks when it comes to financial wellbeing and, as with everything else in this step, it's something that needs constant practice.

Once you have your budget, which is, in a lot of ways, the keystone for your financial habits, it's important that you check in with it, and also with the bank account or accounts that it relates to at regular intervals. This could be daily, weekly or monthly, according to what suits you, but if you're used to avoidance tactics when it comes to money, something more regular will help you to get used to feeling connected and engaged with your finances in a healthy way. This is where exposure therapy tactics can be really useful.

Formally, exposure therapy is a form of cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT) that's usually used for treating phobias, obsessive compulsive disorder and anxiety,³ and it's carried out by a psychotherapist or specialized practitioner. What we are talking about here, though, is using some of the techniques and principles to make facing your finances easier if you experience high levels of anxiety around money – so that the inclination to bury your head in the sand becomes weaker, and you can engage with your finances in a more relaxed and controlled way.